feudal land tenure that arose in Gupta times. This system, according to Bernier, explains why ‘most towns in Hindoustan are made up of earth, mud, and other wretched materials’ and the ‘decline of the Asiatic states’, presumably relative to Europe’s rising fortunes in its age of exploration and colonization. His account reveals a powerful extractive bureaucracy concentrating riches at the top, sustaining a huge army and funding the lavish lives of the aristocrats, not to mention ‘the enormous expenses of the Seraglio, where the consumption of fine cloths of gold, and brocades, silks, embroideries, pearls, musk, amber and sweet essences, is greater than can be conceived’. Millions, he writes, ‘depend for support solely on the King’s pay. Is it possible, [as many] have asked, that any revenue can suffice for such incredible expenditure?’ They seem ‘to forget the riches of the Great Mogol, and the peculiar manner in which Hindoustan is governed’.

Consequently, ‘the inhabitants have less the appearance of a moneyed people than those of many other parts of the globe’. Bernier’s portrait of the extreme disparities in India agrees with the testimony of Athanasius Nikitin, a Russian traveller in the fifteenth century: ‘Those in the country are very miserable, whilst the nobles are extremely opulent and delight in luxury.’ This is at odds with the *sone ki chidiya* (golden bird) imagery often invoked about precolonial India, likely based on the accounts of foreign travellers who hobnobbed with the social elites and reported on their great wealth—even as the commoners were no better off than in other parts of the world.

Further, as Bernier writes, much of the oft-remarked fabulous wealth of Hindoustan existed in gold, diamonds, and ‘a prodigious quantity of pearls and gems of all kinds, of great size and value’. Bernier doubts ‘whether any other Monarch possesses more of this species of wealth . . . But all these precious stones, and valuable articles, are the spoils of ancient princes, Patons and Rajas, collected during a long course of years, and, increasing regularly under every reign’. However, Bernier astutely points out, ‘upon the security of [such wealth] the King, in a time of pressing necessity, would find it extremely difficult to raise the smallest sum’.

Given all this, Bernier asks, ‘Can it excite wonder, that under these circumstances, the arts do not flourish here as they would do under a better government, or as they flourish in our happier France? No artist can be expected to give his mind to his calling in the midst of a people who are either wretchedly poor, or who, if rich, assume an appearance of poverty,